

wiped out, the loss exceeded \$55,000,000,000. From the top of the boom to December, 1931, the net shrinkage was nearly \$66,000,000,000.

WALL STREET, THE INDIAN GIVER

These statistics make no more impression on the average mind than the figures of the distance to Betelgeuse. They are too great to grasp. And at that, these unassimilable sums represent only a part of the total depreciation. If we were to include the losses in the value of unlisted stocks and of all kinds of bonds and real estate and commercial and banking failures, it would be found that the aggregate realizable assets of the American people have temporarily shrunk beyond calculation. After considering these figures, I am convinced that the most remarkable thing about it all is that we could take such a loss and still live—buy and sell and vote. Less than 3 per cent of the American people pay an income tax to Uncle Sam, and 90 per cent of the entire tax is paid by less than one-quarter of 1 per cent of the population. The 1930 tax figures showed that the sturdy old 3 per cent of the population suffered a loss in income running into the hundreds of millions; and, of course, the 1931 income will show still greater losses. The boom that turned so many average Americans into stock-market millionaires in 1928 and 1929 was an Indian giver. It gave, and then proceeded to take away far more than it had given.

But it has been discovered that the losses of millions by millions have more than a conversational value: They automatically become the universal and unassailable alibi. Ask any doctor, banker, landlord, credit manager or any seller of anything. All will testify that they get the same answer from customers: "I lost every cent I had in the world in the stock market and I haven't had a chance to get any of it back. I will pay as soon as I can. . . . No, I can't pay you a part of it."